

National Heritage Areas

National Heritage Areas are places where natural, cultural, historic and scenic resources combine to form a cohesive, nationally important landscape arising from patterns of human activity shaped by geography. These patterns make National Heritage Areas representative of the American experience through the physical features that remain and the traditions that have evolved in them. These regions are acknowledged by Congress for their capacity to tell important stories about our nation. Continued use of National Heritage Areas by people whose traditions helped to shape the landscape enhances their significance.



Blue Ridge National Heritage Area
Vicki Dameron

How National Heritage Areas Work

National Heritage Areas expand on traditional approaches to resource stewardship by supporting large-scale, community centered initiatives that connect local citizens to the preservation and planning process. Inaugurated in 1984, with the designation of the Illinois & Michigan Canal National Heritage Corridor, the National Heritage Areas movement now encompasses 40 areas, ranging from factory towns and city neighborhoods to farmland and battlefields. By embracing large landscapes, National Heritage Areas have the ability to join together diverse interests such as education, recreation, heritage tourism and historic preservation. Committed to protecting and promoting the historic, cultural and natural assets of a region, National Heritage Areas play a vital role in maintaining both the physical character and cultural legacy of the United States.

In National Heritage Areas, residents, businesses, governments and non-profit organizations collaborate to promote conservation, community revitalization and economic development projects. Through



Shenandoah Valley Battlefields National Historic District
Elizabeth Paradis Stern

the facilitation of a local coordinating entity, such as a private non-profit corporation or a public commission, residents come together to improve regional quality of life through the protection of shared cultural and natural resources. This cooperative approach allows National Heritage Areas to achieve both conservation and economic growth in ways that do not compromise local land use controls. Long-term National Heritage Area success depends upon the willing support and activities of partner organizations and residents, who collaborate from the very beginning to develop and implement an area's mission and goals. Participation in projects and programs is always voluntary with zoning and land-use decisions remaining under the jurisdiction of local governments.

A Partnership with the National Park Service

The National Park Service (NPS) provides technical, planning and limited financial assistance to National Heritage Areas. The NPS is a partner and advisor, leaving decision-making authority in the hands of local people and organizations.

This partnership allows the NPS to further its core mission of natural and historic resource protection, while also leveraging financial and non-financial resources for all parties involved. Additionally, while a National Heritage Area designation is permanent, the role of the NPS can vary over time in response to the needs of the region and its residents.

Essex National Heritage Area
Trip Mason



Mormon Pioneer National Heritage Area



Upper Housatonic Valley National Heritage Area



Augusta Canal National Heritage Area
Rebecca Rogers



Lackawanna Heritage Valley National Heritage Area

Becoming a National Heritage Area

National Heritage Areas are designated by Congress. Each National Heritage Area is governed by separate authorizing legislation and operates under provisions unique to its resources and desired goals. For an area to be considered for designation, certain key elements must be present. First and foremost, the landscape must have nationally distinctive natural, cultural, historic and scenic resources that, when linked together, tell a unique story about our country. A strong base of local, grassroots support is also essential, with the visible involvement and commitment of residents, government, community groups, non-profits and businesses. A feasibility study, conducted with extensive public involvement, is also strongly recommended. This document defines the region's story, identifies significant assets and shows local support for the initiative. Interested communities can learn more about the feasibility study process at www.nps.gov/history/heritageareas or contact a National Park Service office in their region of the country. The Alliance of National Heritage Areas also offers information on heritage development at www.nationalheritageareas.com.

Newly designated National Heritage Areas have three years to develop a management plan, which, upon completion, must be approved by the Secretary of the Interior. The plan defines the mission, vision and goals of the National Heritage Area and outlines the strategies that the coordinating entity, partners and residents will use to achieve these objectives. Implementation of the plan rests in the hands of local citizens, officials, organizations and businesses, not the federal government.



Yuma Crossing National Heritage Area



Silos & Smokestacks National Heritage Area



Great Basin National Heritage Route
Kristi Fillman



Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor
Tim Etter



The National Heritage Area Experience

As part of a living, working landscape, National Heritage Areas are not governed by the same policies as traditional National Park Service units; rather, they reflect the diverse and evolving histories and cultures of the people who call the region home. Sometimes, you will see a "Welcome" sign when you enter a National Heritage Area; other times, you may have to look a bit closer to know that you have arrived. Above all, listen, for as you meet residents who live in these special places, you will hear stories about the region and its place in our national history.

National Heritage Areas offer recreational activities and cultural events for all ages and interests. These may include hiking, biking and paddling or trips to museums and festivals. Take a stroll through a historic downtown or visit a wildlife reserve, there is always something to do or to see in these unique places. Many National Heritage Areas also participate in the "Passport to your National Parks" program, which encourages visitors to collect cancellation stamps every time they enter a unit of the National Park System, National Trail, Affiliated Area or National Heritage Area. A list of National Heritage Area stamping locations is available at www.nps.gov/history/heritageareas.

Quinebaug and Shetucket Rivers Valley National Heritage Corridor
G. Leslie Sweetnam

National Heritage Areas



Northern Rio Grande National Heritage Area
Samuel Delgado

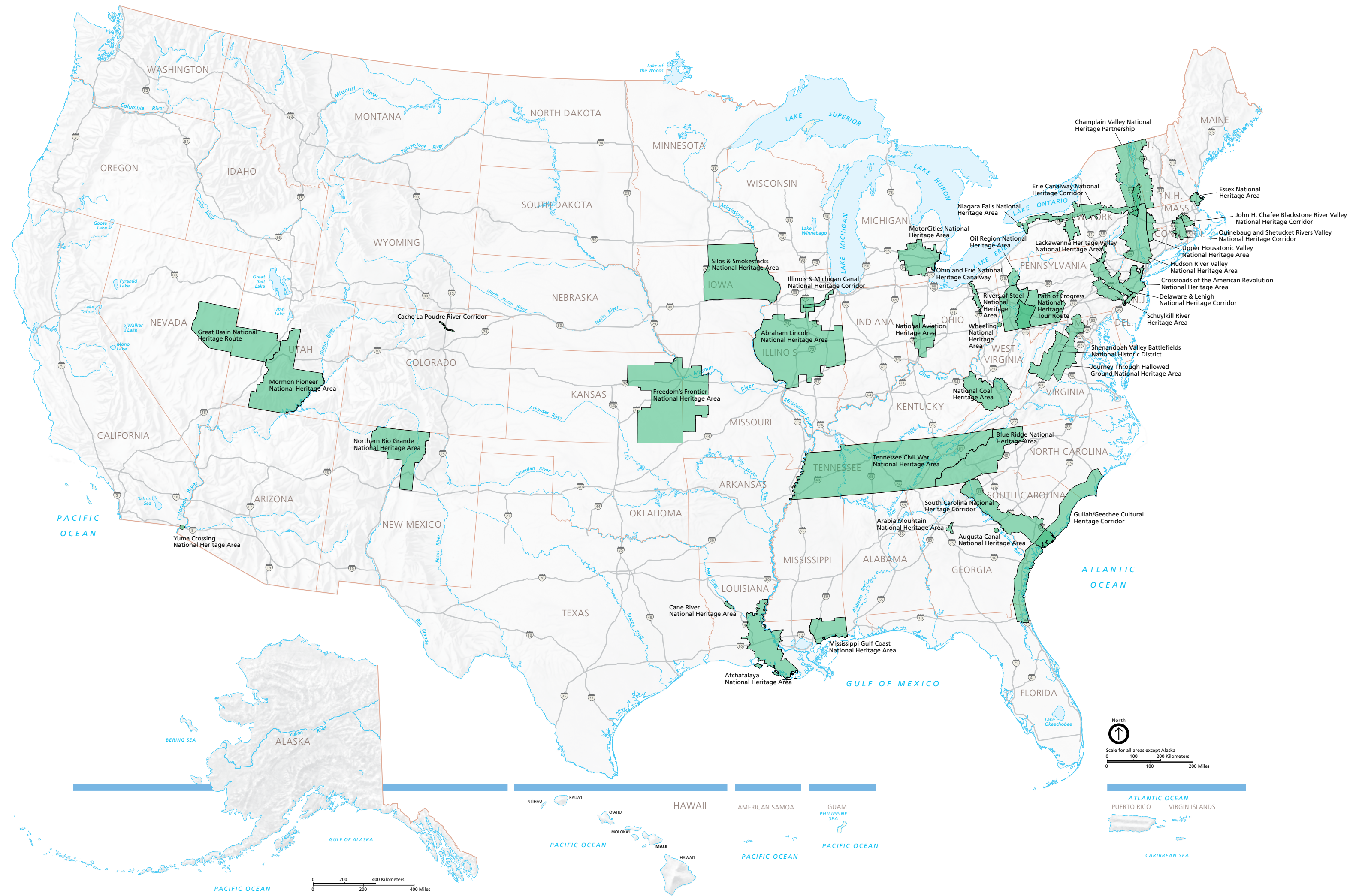
Atchafalaya National Heritage Area

Tennessee Civil War National Heritage Area

Rivers of Steel National Heritage Area

Champlain Valley National Heritage Partnership
Local Motion

National Aviation Heritage Area
Neil Raymond



Ohio and Erie National Heritage Canalway
Ken Robinson



Schuylkill River Heritage Area
D. Creighton



Gullah/Geechee Cultural Heritage Corridor
D. Laird



Oil Region National Heritage Area



Crossroads of the American Revolution National Heritage Area



National Coal Heritage Area

National Heritage Areas Contact Information

Abraham Lincoln National Heritage Area
(217) 782-6817
<http://www.lookingforlincoln.com>

Arabia Mountain National Heritage Area
(770) 484-3060
<http://www.arabialliance.org>

Atchafalaya National Heritage Area
(225) 342-3413
<http://www.atchafalaya.org>

Augusta Canal National Heritage Area
(706) 823-0440
<http://www.augustacanal.com>

Blue Ridge National Heritage Area
(828) 298-5330
<http://www.blueridgeheritage.com>

Cache La Poudre River Corridor
(970) 350-9755
<http://www.fortnet.org/PRHerCor/index.htm>

Cane River National Heritage Area
(318) 356-5555
<http://www.caneriverheritage.org>

Champlain Valley National Heritage Partnership
(802) 372-3213
<http://www.champlainvalleynhp.org>

Crossroads of the American Revolution National Heritage Area
(609) 633-2060
<http://www.revolutionarynj.org>

Delaware & Lehigh National Heritage Corridor
(610) 923-3548
<http://www.delawareandlehigh.org>

Erie Canalway National Heritage Corridor
(518) 237-7000
<http://www.eriecanalway.org>

Essex National Heritage Area
(978) 740-0444
<http://www.essexheritage.org>

Freedom's Frontier National Heritage Area
(785) 865-4499
<http://www.freedomsfrontier.org>

Great Basin National Heritage Route
(775) 234-7171
<http://www.greatbasinheritage.org>

Gullah/Geechee Cultural Heritage Corridor
(843) 881-5516
<http://www.nps.gov/guge>

Hudson River Valley National Heritage Area
(518) 473-3835
<http://www.hudsonrivervalley.com>

Illinois & Michigan Canal National Heritage Corridor
(815) 588-1100
<http://www.canalcor.org>

John H. Chafee Blackstone River Valley National Heritage Corridor
(401) 762-0250
<http://www.nps.gov/blac>

Journey Through Hallowed Ground National Heritage Area
(540) 882-4929
<http://www.hallowedground.org>

Lackawanna Heritage Valley National Heritage Area
(570) 963-6730
<http://www.lhva.org>

Mississippi Gulf Coast National Heritage Area
(228) 523-4122
<http://www.msgulfcoastheritage.ms.gov>

Mormon Pioneer National Heritage Area
(435) 462-2456
<http://www.mormonpioneerheritage.org>

MotorCities National Heritage Area
(313) 259-3425
<http://www.motorcities.org>

National Aviation Heritage Area
(937) 443-0165
<http://www.visitnaha.com>

National Coal Heritage Area
(304) 256-6941
<http://www.coalheritage.org>

Niagara Falls National Heritage Area
(215) 597-2699
<http://www.nps.gov/nifa>

Northern Rio Grande National Heritage Area
(505) 753-0937
<http://www.nps.gov/history/heritageareas/areas/norg.htm>

Ohio and Erie National Heritage Canalway
(330) 434-5657
<http://www.ohioanderiecanalway.com/>

Oil Region National Heritage Area
(814) 677-3152
<http://www.oilregion.org>

Path of Progress National Heritage Tour Route
(814) 472-0873
<http://www.nps.gov/papr>

Quinebaug and Shetucket Rivers Valley National Heritage Corridor
(860) 774-3300
<http://www.thelastgreenvally.org>

Rivers of Steel National Heritage Area
(412) 464-4020
<http://www.riversofsteel.com>

Schuylkill River Heritage Area
(484) 945-0200
<http://www.schuylkillriver.org>

Shenandoah Valley Battlefields National Historic District
(540) 740-4545
<http://www.shenandoahAtWar.org>

Silos & Smokestacks National Heritage Area
(319) 234-4567
<http://www.silosandsmokestacks.org>

South Carolina National Heritage Corridor
(864) 338-4841
<http://www.sc-heritagecorridor.org>

Tennessee Civil War National Heritage Area
(615) 898-2947
<http://www.tncivilwar.org>

Upper Housatonic Valley National Heritage Area
(860) 435-9505
<http://www.housatonicheritage.org>

Wheeling National Heritage Area
(304) 232-3087
<http://www.wheelingheritage.org>

Yuma Crossing National Heritage Area
(928) 373-5198
<http://www.yumaheritage.com>



Hudson River Valley National Heritage Area
James Bleeker



South Carolina National Heritage Corridor

How to Learn More

National Park Service
National Heritage Areas Program Office
1201 "Eye" Street, N.W., 6th Floor
Washington, D.C. 20005
(202) 354-2268
<http://www.nps.gov/history/heritageareas>

Alliance of National Heritage Areas
1101 30th Street, N.W., Suite 500
Washington, D.C. 20007
(202) 625-4393
<http://www.nationalheritageareas.com>



Since 1916, the National Park Service has been the federal agency responsible for preserving nationally significant natural, cultural and historic resources for present and future generations. National Park Service staff serve as

partners, working with local community members to assist in the planning and implementation of National Heritage Area activities.

Membership of the Alliance of National Heritage Areas (ANHA) advocates, facilitates and celebrates excellence in cooperative initiatives that enhance quality of life for citizens and their communities. These projects create opportunities for cultural heritage tourism and provide examples of sustainable heritage development for the nation. ANHA enables Heritage Areas, at all levels of development, to share professional expertise, entrepreneurship, knowledge and connections through its Heritage Development Institute, publications, conferences and Annual Meeting.

This brochure was produced under a cooperative agreement with the National Conference of State Historic Preservation Officers.

Mention of trade names does not constitute an endorsement by the U.S. Government.